VICTORY 2027

Treasure Chest : POETRY

# Haunted House

(Part-2)

Lecture 2 | ENGLISH

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# TOPICS TO BE COVERED

1. Stanza-wise Explanation
2. Keywords
3. Theme and Tone
4. Poetic Devices
5. Q/Answers



# Topic : Stanza- 1

*All houses wherein men have lived and died*
*Are haunted houses. Through the open doors*
*The harmless phantoms on their errands glide,*
*With feet that make no sound upon the floors.*

**1. Houses of Human Life**

All houses where people have lived and died→ Are called *haunted houses*

**2. Nature of the Ghosts**

Ghosts are:

- Harmless
- Quiet
- Invisible

(They move silently through open doors)



# Topic : Explanation

The first line sets the premise that every house in which people have lived and died is metaphorically haunted. The haunting represents the memories and the history of the people who once inhabited those houses.

He refers to the spirits as 'harmless phantoms', emphasizing that they are not terrifying but rather peaceful echoes of the past. These phantoms are silent, invisible presences who go about their daily tasks, much like the people who once lived there did.



# Topic : Stanza- 2

Corridors of a building

***We meet them at the door way, on the stair,***
***Along the passages they come and go,***
***Impalpable impressions on the air,***
***A sense of something moving to and fro***

not able to touch or see (Incomprehensible)

**3. Their Movement**

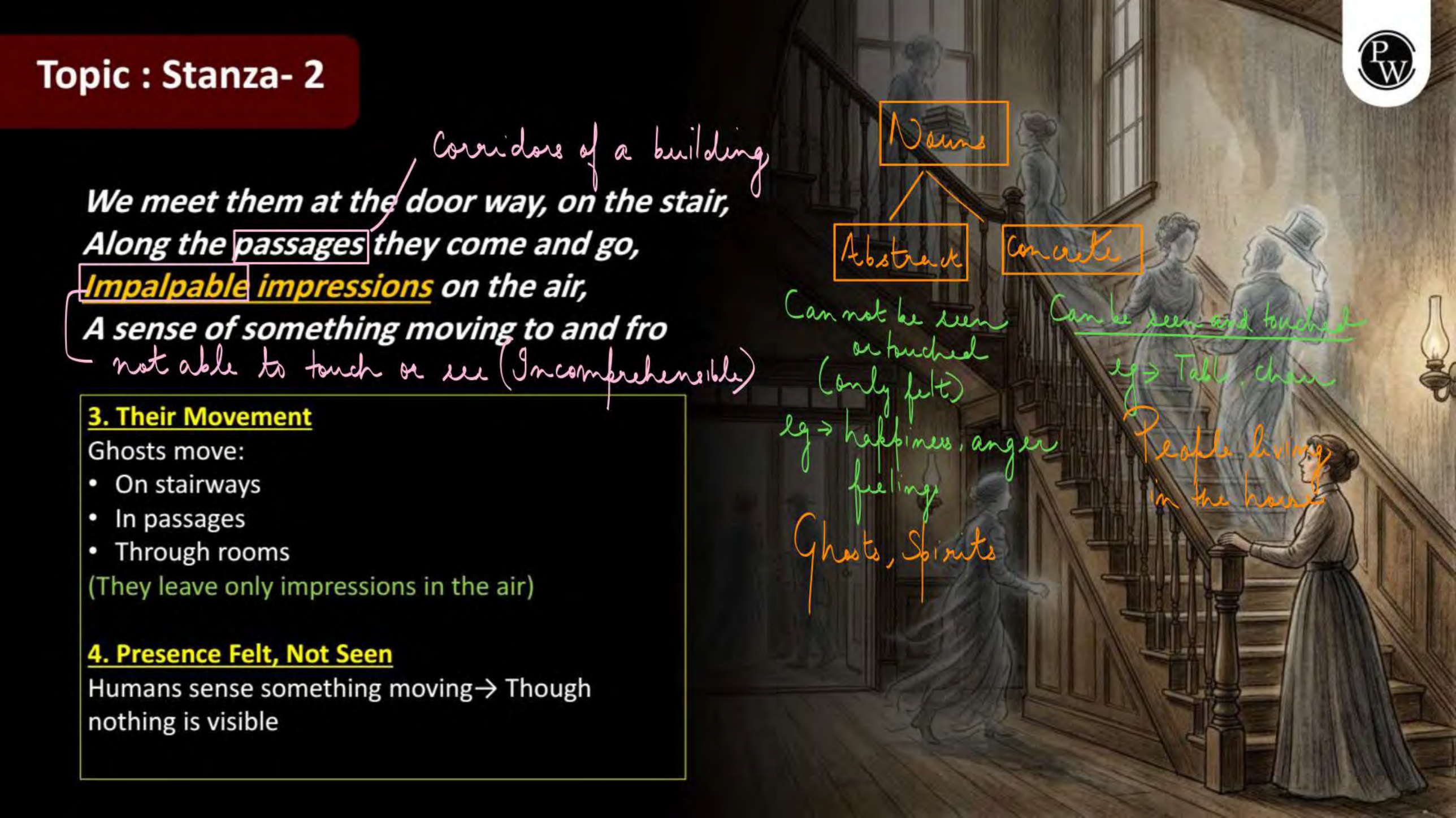
Ghosts move:

- On stairways
- In passages
- Through rooms

(They leave only impressions in the air)

**4. Presence Felt, Not Seen**

Humans sense something moving→ Though nothing is visible



# Topic : Stanza- 3

*There are more guests at table than the hosts*
*Invited; the illuminated hall*
*Is thronged with quiet, inoffensive ghosts,*
*As silent as the pictures on the wall.*

**5. More Ghosts Than Living People**

At gatherings, ghosts outnumber the living (They remain silent and peaceful)



# Topic : Stanza- 4

*The stranger at my fireside cannot see*
*The forms I see, nor hear the sounds I hear;*
*He but perceives what is; while unto me*
*All that has been is visible and clear.*

Spirits

becomes aware




**6. Difference in Perception**

A stranger sees only the present (The poet sees both past and present together)

# Topic : Stanza- 5

legal documents of ownership

*We have no **title-deeds** to house or lands;*
*Owners and occupants of earlier dates*
*From graves forgotten **stretch** their dusty hands,*
*And **hold in mortmain** still their old **estates.***

property held in an inalienable position

**7. Idea of Ownership**
Living people do not truly own houses or land

**8. Claim of the Dead**
Past owners still hold invisible claims
Their memories continue to exist



## Central Theme

Co-existence of Past, Present and Spiritual World

## Topic : Stanza- 6

Alliteration

① Co-existence of both worlds
② Essentiality of spiritual world

The spirit-world around this world of sense
Spiritual world — Physical world

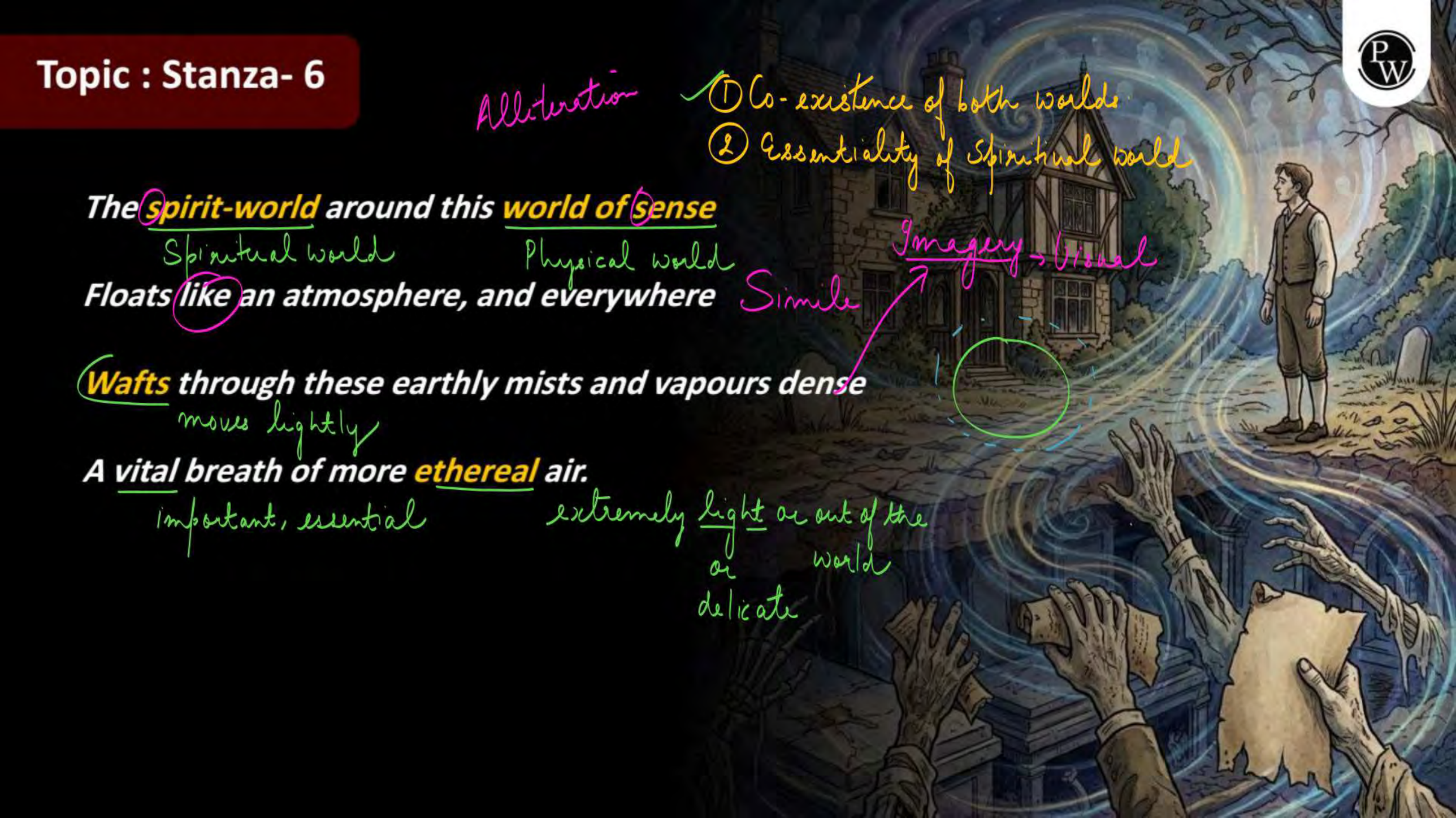
Floats like an atmosphere, and everywhere

Simile

Imagery → Visual

Wafts through these earthly mists and vapours dense
moves lightly

A vital breath of more ethereal air.
important, essential — extremely light or out of the world or delicate



# Topic : Explanation

Simile → like

Atmosphere → Spiritual world.

kingdom

1. **The Spirit-World:** The poem describes a realm beyond our physical reality, a world of spirits or a spiritual dimension. Floats like an atmosphere: The spiritual world is compared to an atmosphere. Just as the atmosphere envelops the Earth, the spiritual world envelops our lives.

Spiritual world = mists and vapour

1. **Wafts through earthly mists and vapors dense:** The poem describes the spiritual energy as moving gently (wafts) through the dense, earthly surroundings (mists and vapours).

## Topic : Stanza- 7

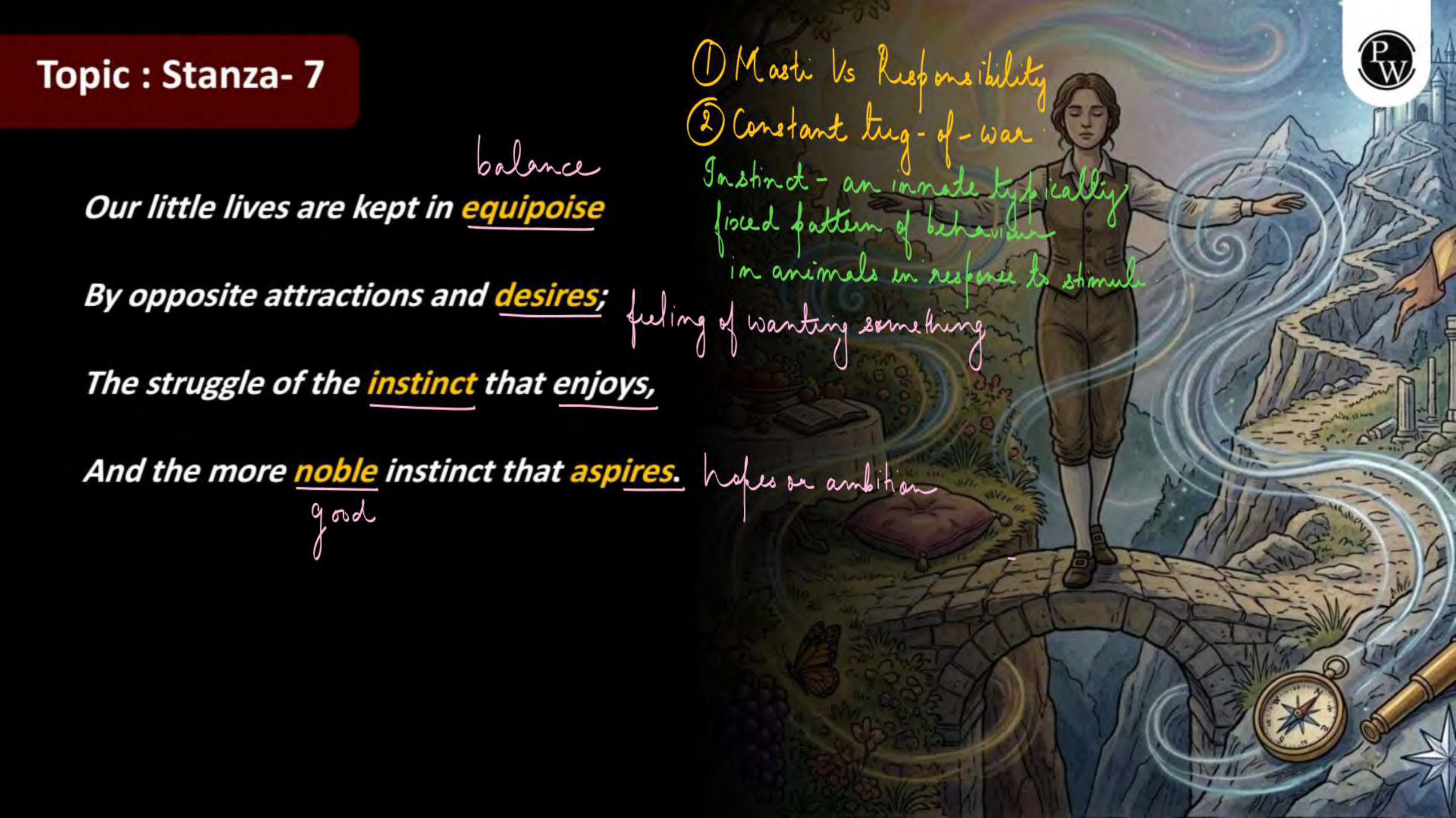
balance
*Our little lives are kept in equipoise*

*By opposite attractions and desires;* feeling of wanting something

*The struggle of the instinct that enjoys,*

*And the more noble instinct that aspires.* hopes or ambition
good

① Masti Vs Responsibility
② Constant tug-of-war
Instinct - an innate typically fixed pattern of behaviour in animals in response to stimuli



# Topic : Explanation

**Key Ideas:**

1. **Balance in life:** The poem describes human lives in a state of balance or equilibrium. This balance is maintained by opposing forces or desires.
2. **Inner conflict:** The poem highlights the struggle between two instincts:
   - **The instinct that enjoys:** This refers to our basic desires, needs, and pleasures. It's the part of us that seeks happiness, comfort, and satisfaction.
   - **The more noble instinct that aspires:** This represents our higher aspirations, goals, and values. It's the part of us that strives for growth, improvement, and transcendence.

go beyond limit

# Topic : Explanation

3. **The Struggle:** The poem suggests that our lives are characterized by a constant interplay between these two instincts.

- On one hand, we have desires and needs that drive us to seek pleasure and comfort.
- On the other hand, we have aspirations and values that push us to strive for something greater.



# Topic: MCQ

What does *"equipoise"* mean in the context of the poem?

A) Elegance

B) Balance or equilibrium

C) Fear or terror

D) Unevenness

## Topic : Stanza- 8

Conflict or disturbances

*These perturbations, this perpetual jar* → a harsh, discordant sound

Continuous

*Of earthly wants and aspirations high,*

*Come from the influence of an unseen star,* → fate, destiny

*An undiscovered planet in our sky.* → motivation



# Topic : Explanation

**Key Ideas:**

1. **Conflict/ Turmoil in life:** The poem describes "perturbations" and a "perpetual jar" (or conflict), highlighting the challenges and tensions we face in life.
2. **Earthly wants vs. high aspirations:** This contrast highlights the inner conflict we often face: balancing our immediate desires with our long-term goals and values.
3. **Influence of an unseen force:** The poem attributes these challenges and tensions to the influence of "an unseen star" or "an undiscovered planet" in our lives.

# Topic : Explanation

**The Unseen Force:** The "unseen star" or "undiscovered planet" can be interpreted in various ways:

- **Fate or destiny:** The poem might suggest that our lives are influenced by forces beyond our control, shaping our experiences and challenges.
- **Inner drives or motivations:** The unseen force could represent our inner desires, values, or passions that guide us, even if we're not fully aware of them.
- **External circumstances:** The poem might also imply that external factors, such as societal expectations, relationships, or environmental factors, impact our lives in ways we don't fully understand.

# Topic: MCQ

What does the term *"perturbations"* mean in the poem?

A) Moments of peace

B) Moments of clarity

C) Disturbances or changes

D) Moments of happiness

# Topic : Stanza- 9

*And as the moon from some dark gate of cloud*

*Throws o'er the sea a floating bridge of light,*

*Across whose trembling planks our fancies crowd*

*Into the realm of mystery and night*



# Topic : Explanation

Longfellow introduces the metaphor of a bridge of light formed by the moonlight across the sea. This bridge, upon which our thoughts and fancies traverse, leads us into a realm of mystery and darkness-possibly representing the unknown or the spiritual world.



# Topic: MCQ

What descends from the world of spirits?

Comes down

A) A rain of sorrow

B) A bridge of light

C) A loud noise

D) An array of colours

# Topic : Stanza- 10

*So from the world of spirits there descends*

*A bridge of light, connecting it with this.*

*O'er whose unsteady floor, that sways and bends,*

*Wander our thoughts above the dark abyss.*



# Topic : Explanation



**Key Ideas:**

1. **Bridge of light:** A connection between the spiritual realm and our world.
2. **Unsteady floor:** The bridge is fragile and uncertain, symbolizing the challenges of navigating between the spiritual and material worlds.
3. **Thoughts wandering:** Our minds explore and traverse this bridge, bridging the gap between the two realms.

# Topic: MCQ

What is the overall theme of Longfellow's poem, *'Haunted House'?*

A) The terror of ghosts

B) The beauty of haunted houses

C) The dangers of living in old houses

D) The connection between the past, the present and the spiritual realm

# Topic: Keywords

Haunted houses, harmless phantoms, memories, past and present, silent ghosts, impressions, human life, time, mortality, Spirit-world, material world, ethereal atmosphere, earthly mist, equipoise (balance), opposite attractions, earthly desires, noble aspirations, inner conflict, instinct that enjoys, instinct that aspires, unseen influence, undiscovered planet, moon imagery, bridge of light, imagination, mystery, human mind, spiritual connection

# Topic: Theme and Tone

Read

The central theme of *Haunted Houses* is that **the human mind and heart are haunted by memories of the past**. Longfellow suggests that all houses in which people have lived and died are filled with invisible presences—not frightening ghosts, but **memories, thoughts, and impressions of earlier lives**.

**The poem also explores:**

- The **coexistence of past and present**
- The **influence of unseen spiritual forces** on human life

**Tone**

The tone of the poem is **calm, reflective, and philosophical.**

# Topic : Poetic Device

1.Metaphor: This device is used throughout the poem to compare two unlike thinks without using *"like" or "as"*. For instance, the poem compares houses where people have lived and died to 'haunted houses" filled with harmless phantoms or spirits. The bridge of light' is a metaphor for the connection between the physical and the spiritual world.

2.Personification: This device given human characteristics to non-human. For example "From graves forgotten stretch their dusty hands" attributes the human action of stretching hands to graves, creating a vivid and haunting image.

# Topic : Poetic Device

3. **Alliteration:** The repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words. In *"A sense of something moving to and fro.",* the repeated 's' sound creates a soft, whisper-like effect that enhances the ghostly atmosphere.

4. **Assonance:** This device, involving the repetition of vowel sounds, is used in "The stranger at my fireside cannot see", where the repeated 'a' sound creates a rhythmic effect.

# Topic : Poetic Device

5. **Paradox:** This device uses seemingly contradictory statements that may nonetheless be true. For instance,

Self- contradictory idea

eg → less is more

*"We have no title-deeds to house or lands;*
*Owners and occupants of earlier dates*
*From graves forgotten stretch their dusty hands,"*

highlights the paradoxical idea of ownership

## Topic : Theme of the Poem

The poet wants to convey that ghosts are harmless, and they visit their dwelling places where they once lived as humans. Also, they remain with their beloved, forever.



# PYQ-2025

**Read the following extract from H.W. Longfellow's poem, 'Haunted Houses' and answer the questions that follow:**

*The stranger at my fireside cannot see*
*The forms I see, nor hear the sounds I hear;*
*He but perceives what is; while unto me*
*All that has been is visible and clear*

**(i) What makes the poet-narrator different from the stranger at his fireside?** **[3]**

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*The forms I see, nor hear the sounds I hear;*
*He but perceives what is; while unto me*
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**(ii) What, according to the poet, turns a house into a 'haunted' house?**

**[3]**

# PYQ-2025

**Read the following extract from H.W. Longfellow's poem, 'Haunted Houses' and answer the questions that follow:**

*The stranger at my fireside cannot see*
*The forms I see, nor hear the sounds I hear;*
*He but perceives what is; while unto me*
*All that has been is visible and clear*

**(iii) Where is one likely to meet the 'phantoms' in a haunted house?**

**[3]**

# PYQ-2025

**Read the following extract from H.W. Longfellow's poem, 'Haunted Houses' and answer the questions that follow:**

*The stranger at my fireside cannot see*
*The forms I see, nor hear the sounds I hear;*
*He but perceives what is; while unto me*
*All that has been is visible and clear*

**(iv) What are the poet-narrator's views on owning property?**

# PYQ-2025

**Read the following extract from H.W. Longfellow's poem, 'Haunted Houses' and answer the questions that follow:**

*The stranger at my fireside cannot see*
*The forms I see, nor hear the sounds I hear;*
*He but perceives what is; while unto me*
*All that has been is visible and clear*

**(v) How do the poet's views of ghosts differ from the traditional perception of ghosts? How would you describe the mood that the poem evokes? Give ONE reason for your answer.**

# Extract based Questions

Read the stanza given below and answer the questions that follow:

*We have no title-deeds to house or lands;*
*Owners and occupants of earlier dates*
*From graves forgotten stretch their dusty hands*
*And hold in mortmain still their old estates.*

(i) Do the current inhabitants have legal ownership of the house and lands mentioned in the stanza?

(ii) Who are the "owners and occupants of earlier dates"?

(iii) What does it mean for the earlier inhabitants to "stretch their dusty hands"?

(iv) What is the significance of the phrase "graves forgotten" in relation to the earlier inhabitants?

(v) What do you think the phrase "hold in mortmain still their old estates" suggests?

# Extract based Questions

(i) The line "We have no title-deeds to house or lands" suggests that the current occupants lack legal documentation or proof of ownership. This indicates that they may not have a recognised legal claim to the property. Instead, the stanza emphasises the presence of earlier owners and occupants who, despite being from forgotten graves, still retain a hold on their "old estates" through a concept called "mortmain". It suggests that the earlier inhabitants, even in death, continue to exert some form of influence or ownership over the property. Therefore, the lack of title-deeds and the mention of the earlier inhabitants holding on to their old estates in "mortmain" imply that the current occupants may not have legal ownership rights to the house and lands mentioned in the stanza.

(i) The "owners and occupants of earlier dates" referred to in the stanza are the individuals who lived in the house and owned the lands before the current inhabitants. They are the previous generations of people who have inhabited and had ownership of the property. The stanza suggests that these earlier owners and occupants have passed away and now exist in a forgotten state, represented by their "dusty hands" reaching out from their graves. Although they are no longer physically present, their presence is metaphorically felt, as they still hold a connection to the property and their "old estates" through the concept of "mortmain".

# Extract based Questions

(iii) The phrase "stretch their dusty hands" is a metaphorical expression used to describe the actions of the earlier inhabitants. It symbolises their connection from beyond the grave to the current occupants and their surroundings. By using the term "dusty hands," the poet suggests that the earlier inhabitants have long been absent, forgotten, or buried, emphasising their connection to the past. The act of stretching their hands implies an attempt to make their presence felt, to exert some influence or maintain a connection to the property. The metaphorical gesture of stretching hands can represent a variety of things, such as a desire to hold onto their past ownership or to reach out for acknowledgment, remembrance, or interaction with the current occupants. It might also imply a sense of longing, a yearning to bridge the gap between the past and present.

(iv) The phrase "graves forgotten" holds significance in relation to the earlier inhabitants mentioned in the stanza. It suggests that the resting places of these individuals have been neglected of overlooked over time. The use of the word "forgotten" indicates a lack of remembrance or recognition of their existence and final resting places. This phrase highlights the transient nature of human memory and the passage of time. It implies that the current occupants may not have a direct awareness or conscious knowledge of the specific individuals buried in the graves. Despite being forgotten, the earlier inhabitants are still portrayed as having a connection to the property and exerting an influence on it.

# Extract based Questions

(v) The phrase "hold in mortmain still their old estates" suggests that the previous owners and occupants of the house or lands continue to exert a kind of lasting control or influence over the property, even after their physical existence. The term "mortmain" refers to the legal concept of property held by an organisation or institution that cannot be alienated or transferred. In this context, it signifies the unyielding grip the past has on the property as if the hands of the previous owners and occupants, even from forgotten graves, still tightly hold onto their "old estates." This phrase implies that the history, memories, and legacies of the past inhabitants remain deeply embedded within the property. Their presence lingers, metaphorically "holding" the property in a state of continuity with itsearlier times. It suggests that the influence of the past is not easily erased or forgotten, emphasising the enduring connection between the present and the history of the property.


Thank You!